

Unholy Row

Last week when Praful Vaghela broke his fast at the insistence of Chief Minister Narendra Modi, the state Government heaved a sigh of relief. Vaghela had been on an eight-day-long fast to demand justice and a CBI probe for the deaths of his son Abhishek, 9, and nephew Dipesh, 10. He alleges that the boys were killed by tantriks in a human sacrifice at Asaram Bapu's ashram in Ahmedabad. For almost a week, citizens, political parties, leftist organisations, social groups and common citizens had led violent protests on the streets of Ahmedabad. They torched vehicles and clashed with Bapu's followers in a burst of frenzy whipped by public revulsion against the godman.

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STREET STRIFE: Journalists protest attacks by Bapu's followers

bed of the Sabarmati river by locals. One of the corpses had body parts missing, a possible indication that they had been killed in a human sacrifice as crucial body parts of children are normally used by tantriks in their rituals. The other body's ears had been eaten away by dogs. Bapu's initial silence over the issue only inflamed passions of local residents. Then came the police statement that the deaths had occurred due to drowning and that the bodies had been eaten by dogs, which only added fuel to the already simmering dissent. Bapu's initial silence and his belated statement that there was an attempt by his enemies to create a wedge between the people and the

Violence hits the streets as Asaram Bapu's disciples and locals go on a rampage after charges of human sacrifices

Sant Samaj only caused further provocation. The last straw was when rioters attacked Bapu's followers, who retaliated by beating up journalists and residents around the ashram who had been supporting the protests.

The post-mortem report has not provided a clear reason for the deaths of the boys. It revealed that the sternum and liver of one of the boys was missing. The state Government has promised Vaghela an impartial probe. "If I don't get justice, I will renew my demand for a CBI probe," says Vaghela. Till then, the suspicions and ugly rumours swirling around the ashram will continue to grow.

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A series of well-managed pro-poor and impressive programmes, however, tend to cover up his controversial side. Bapu organises well publicised welfare programmes. His ashrams run medical services, distribute free foodgrain among the poor, who form the bulk of his followers. His anti-addiction programme is also another big draw. Not surprisingly, Bapu avoids the media when it comes to questions about the controversies. Uday Sanghani, the ashram's spokesman, counters the charges on the godman's behalf. "These empty allegations about illicit

land deals, money-making and violence by Bapu and his followers are a creation of those who have not been able to stomach Bapu's rise and his acceptability among the masses as a spiritual master," he says. "These people are finding newer and newer ways of upsetting Bapu's appellation. But Bapu is undisturbed by their antics as his mission is that of awakening the people at the spiritual level," Sanghani adds.

With the controversy involving suspicious deaths and attacks on the media, the man behind the "saint" may finally be revealed.